

A Day in Chengdu

Though much of Chengdu is modern, there are many places in the city to soak up a more traditional atmosphere.

MORNING Greet the dawn among scores of martial artists in **Renmin Park**, then catch a cab out to Chengdu's **Panda Breeding Research Base** to watch these endangered creatures breakfasting on fresh bamboo shoots. Return to town for tea at the atmospheric **Green Goat Temple**, dedicated to Taoism's mythic founder, Lao Tzu.

AFTERNOON Ride the bus or walk to **Jin Li**, a lane full of antique-style shops and stands specializing in Sichuan's famous *xiaochi* snacks. Visit the adjacent **Wuhou Memorial Hall**, where emperor Liu Bei of the ancient Shu kingdom is buried, then take a bus to the extraordinary **Jinsha Museum**, packed with cultural relics from the Bronze Age.

EVENING After dark, have supper along **Kuan Xiangzi**, a maze of beautifully restored 19th-century stone lanes and buildings that house some great restaurants. Afterward, catch a short performance of Sichuan opera at the **Shufeng Yayun** theater.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Chengdu has a **train station** and **international airport**. A **metro line** runs south through the city, and **buses** and **taxis** are everywhere.

WHERE TO STAY

Traffic Hotel Chengdu (inexpensive) is a backpacker favorite – clean, friendly, efficient, and in a good central location.

www.trafficotelchengdu.cn

The BuddhaZen Hotel (moderate) is a boutique hotel with a traditional courtyard setting, located in the fascinating “old street” area of Wen Shu Fang. +86 28 8678 1212

The Sofitel Wanda (expensive) is Chengdu's best upmarket option. www.sofitel.com

FURTHER INFORMATION

194 Qintai Road, Chengdu; or check the listings magazine *GoChengdu*: www.gochengdoo.com



Right Drinking cups (*wan*) have lids (*gai*) to catch the leaves of the tea (*cha*); together they form the *gaiwan cha* for drinking tea

Below The teahouses of Chengdu vary from grand old buildings to bamboo-pole stalls in temples and markets

